

Chapter 133-1

Liang Shi hadn't expected that Xu Qingzhu would tell her everything.

She didn't treat Zhao Xuning as an outsider at all.

Perhaps she was simply teasing her.

And Zhao Xuning played along, or rather, she was happy to see Liang Shi embarrass herself. She first let out a quick *tsk*, then drawled out her words: "So that's how it is."

Liang Shi: "....."

She wished she could find a crack in the ground to crawl into.

"Miss Liang, do you need me to prescribe some medicine to help you out?" Zhao Xuning asked with a smile.

Liang Shi: "....."

Normally, Zhao Xuning's face was always sour, never showing anyone a smile.

To observe whether she was in a good mood, you had to look at the subtle details like her tone and gaze—it was particularly difficult.

But now she kept smiling; the corners of her mouth hadn't dropped since entering the private room.

It wasn't because Liang Shi had woken up—she was simply happy teasing Liang Shi.

One's happiness is always built upon another's misery.

Liang Shi glared at her, looked at the wine glasses in front of them, and said through gritted teeth: "How about a competition?"

Zhao Xuning provoked: "Oh? Compete at what?"

Liang Shi: "...Drinking."

"I thought you wanted to compete with me at something else." Zhao Xuning shrugged: "I'm telling you, you can't bring those anything-goes¹ antics to me, or you'd be as good as dead."

Liang Shi: "...Today, don't even think about walking out of this room upright."

Zhao Xuning raised her eyebrow: "So fierce."

Liang Shi: "I have to show you whether I can... do it or not."

The last three words were said through gritted teeth, sounding quite indignant.

Zhao Xuning laughed, "Hey, I wasn't the one who said you couldn't do it—your wife said it. Besides, this is something the two of you can prove to each other. What the hell does it have to do with me?"

Those narrow, fox-like eyes carried a half-smiling expression.

Without her glasses, Zhao Xuning was the alluring type. Normally, she carried herself with an aloof air and a sour expression, making anyone who saw her feel she was unapproachable.

But now she actually showed a few traces of charm.

She clearly hadn't drunk much yet, but her speech was much coarser than usual.

She had probably loosened up.

Liang Shi patted her once, "Drinking or not?"

Zhao Xuning: "...What's the wager?"

Liang Shi: "If you lose, you call Shen Hui and tell her everything in your heart."

Zhao Xuning: "...Can you be any more annoying?"

Xu Qingzhu, sitting to the side, glanced sideways at Liang Shi. The lights in the private room were bright, illuminating her with a gentle and beautiful glow.

Zhao Xuning raised her wine glass and drained it in one gulp, her gaze wandering as she looked at the glass, "Change the wager. Don't bring other people into this."

"She's not just 'other people.'" Liang Shi said: "She's the one you love."

Zhao Xuning: "...Liang Shi."

Zhao Xuning called her name very seriously: "You're being really naggy right now."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together: "That's because you haven't experienced..."

She paused, and her originally gentle voice suddenly became choked with emotion, "That feeling of never being able to see someone again. In that moment, you'd be willing to trade so many things, including your life, but there's nothing you can do. You can't do anything, you can't see that person—it's more terrifying than being separated by death²..."

Liang Shi's eyes turned red as she spoke.

She had just experienced a parting—a parting from that world.

She also truly regarded Zhao Xuning as a friend and didn't want her to keep being so stubborn.

Liang Shi was now so emotional that when she said these words, tears welled up in her eyes.

According to the physical constitution of this world, Alphas were far less emotional than Omegas, naturally lacking a kind of empathy.

But Liang Shi had grown up in another world. Although her body was that of an Alpha, psychologically she had very strong empathy.

Especially after what she had just experienced.

As she spoke, Xu Qingzhu's hand fell on the back of her hand, gently patting it.

Though the back of her hand was touched by coolness, Liang Shi felt warmth.

Zhao Xuning lowered her eyes and listened to her quietly.

Footnotes:

¹ "葷素不忌" (hūn sù bù jì) - literally means "eating both meat and vegetables without restriction," but is commonly used as an idiom meaning someone who is indiscriminate, willing to do anything, or has no limits in what they'll say or do (often with suggestive undertones).

² "天人永隔" (tiān rén yǒng gé) - a Chinese idiom meaning "separated forever between heaven and earth," referring to the permanent separation of death where the living and the dead can never meet again.

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After a moment, Zhao Xuning said: "But what's between us can't be explained in just a sentence or two."

Zhao Xuning downed another glass of wine, "She hates me. She really hates me."

"I've done a lot of things wrong." Zhao Xuning smiled bitterly, "She's such a pampered young lady—how could she possibly forgive me?"

Liang Shi clinked glasses with her, "But you still have to say it."

Liang Shi said: "If you don't say it, won't she never know? And you'll never know whether she hates you or loves you. If you tell her everything, it's the same as handing the choice over to her. She gets to decide on your relationship, and you become the passive one—that's the price you pay for doing wrong."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"Did you go take some relationship counseling course?" Zhao Xuning was puzzled, "How come you're..."

"No." Liang Shi said: "When you face life and death, you'll suddenly understand everything."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

She didn't know where Liang Shi had come up with all these twisted theories, but she didn't really want to talk about these things.

The matters between her and Shen Hui—after they broke up, no matter who asked, she had never mentioned them.

Zhao Xuning just picked up her glass and smiled bitterly: "Alright, let's just drink."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Zhao Xuning." Liang Shi said: "You just care too much about your pride."

Zhao Xuning: "?"

"You're afraid of being rejected." Liang Shi scoffed lightly: "A genius like you has probably never been rejected in your entire life, right?"

Zhao Xuning: "...That's not it."

Liang Shi suddenly transformed into a relationship coach and started giving Zhao Xuning advice: "When you like someone, you should definitely lower your stance. You hand the choice over to her instead of sitting here feeling sorry for yourself and wallowing in self-pity—that's really annoying."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"Shut up." Zhao Xuning said calmly: "Skip this topic."

Liang Shi looked at her with disdain: "You're so annoying."

But she didn't say anything more.

They finally successfully skipped two topics.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu, sitting to the side, was looking at the two voice messages she had sent on her screen.

Then she added: 【This person has had too much to drink and is speaking without filter. Don't mind her.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【I'll educate her again.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Mainly about Zhao Xuning's situation here—I think you should know.】

Shen Hui quickly replied: 【Hm? Why should I know?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【To establish a defense mechanism.】

Shen Hui: 【Haha.jpg】

Shen Hui sent her a voice message.

Xu Qingzhu converted the voice message to text; it said: "Little sister, you're too cute."

Xu Qingzhu: 【It's all for atonement.】

Shen Hui sent another voice message: "This time, she's actually quite right."

Xu Qingzhu: 【...Huh?】

This time Shen Hui sent a long voice message. Xu Qingzhu was about to convert it to text, but her finger slipped and she directly hit play.

And her phone's call volume was very high, interrupting the two people who were still chatting over there.

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Shen Hui's voice carried a hint of amusement, sounding flippant and casual: "That Zhao Xuning, she's just pretending. Her life has been too smooth sailing—everyone has been holding her up on a pedestal since she was little. Even when the two of us dated, I was the one who took the initiative. She's completely fake-serious. If I had to describe her in one word, it would be—outwardly cold but inwardly passionate."¹

The private room instantly fell silent.

Liang Shi and Zhao Xuning looked at each other in dismay, then simultaneously looked toward the source of the voice.

Xu Qingzhu cleared her throat lightly, "Um, well, I was chatting with Shen Hui."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

Now Zhao Xuning had nothing to say. She took on the stance of absolutely having to drink Liang Shi under the table.

The two of them didn't eat much food, but drank quite a lot of wine.

The original body couldn't hold her liquor well, but Liang Shi could.

Especially since Liang Shi was in a good mood today—she drank without any hesitation, going back and forth with Zhao Xuning.

In the end, Zhao Xuning collapsed on the table, and before passing out drunk, she still cursed: "Liang Shi, you're really annoying tonight."

Liang Shi chuckled lightly, the corners of her eyes tinged with red, and said with a bit of drunkenness: "I told you I can drink. I can do it."

After she finished speaking, she heard a laugh ring out in the private room—a cool voice carrying a touch of tenderness, very soft.

Yet it made Liang Shi's ears itch.

Liang Shi pinched her ear, and with somewhat hazy eyes, looked toward Xu Qingzhu.

"What are you laughing at?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu rubbed her nose, the corners of her mouth turning up, "Laughing at you."

Liang Shi: "....."

"You're so annoying." Liang Shi had learned a new phrase from Zhao Xuning and immediately put it to use, though her tone was reproachful and sounded like she was acting spoiled. She leaned closer to Xu Qingzhu and pinched her face, "Are you mocking me?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu refuted: "How could I?"

Liang Shi: "Then why are you laughing?"

"Because you're cute." Xu Qingzhu had also drunk quite a bit.

She sat there listening to them chat, though sometimes the two didn't even chat—they just clinked glasses, raised them, and drank.

Anyone who didn't know better would think they were drowning some deep sorrow.

In reality, it was probably one being competitive and one being heartbroken.

Xu Qingzhu, on the other hand, was purely happy.

After so many days of her heart hanging in suspense, it had finally settled down. The person she had been longing for had returned.

How wonderful.

Xu Qingzhu found drinking by herself quite enjoyable too.

The snow falling outside was beautiful, the lights in the private room were lovely, and everything was full of vitality.

The world in her eyes seemed to have a soft-focus filter over it.

Xu Qingzhu's eyes were like a little deer's, carrying a dewy quality that made one's heart flutter.

Liang Shi stared at her, and after a moment, leaned in and kissed her on those rippling, glistening lips.

Then she reached out and ruffled her hair.

Liang Shi chuckled softly, her voice very low, "Not as cute as you."

Xu Qingzhu's hand fell on her forehead, a smile blooming on her face, yet she gently pushed her away, "Where did you learn all this?"

Liang Shi: "From you."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Xu Qingzhu pinched her waist, "Learning bad habits."

"You're so good." Liang Shi had obviously drunk too much. After drinking with Zhao Xuning all evening, there were too many empty wine bottles beside them to count. When she spoke now, her eyes blinked rapidly, looking both earnest and cute, "How is it learning bad habits?"

Liang Shi's hand fell on Xu Qingzhu's waist, but she couldn't bear to pinch her—she just gently caressed with her fingertips.

Her tone lilted upward slightly, sounding tantalizing to the ears, "Everything I learn from you is good."

Footnotes:

¹ "悶騷" (mèn sāo) - A Chinese slang term describing someone who appears cold, reserved, or serious on the outside, but is actually passionate, wild, or romantic on the inside. It's often used to describe someone who hides their true feelings or desires beneath a composed exterior.

Chapter 133-4

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Xu Qingzhu couldn't withstand her unconscious flirting, and her heart softened into a complete mess.

Just as she was thinking about whether or not to kiss Liang Shi right there in the private room, she received a call from Shen Hui.

It was already very late at this hour—after all, they had nearly drunk until the restaurant was closing.

Shen Hui got straight to the point when she called: "Is she drunk?"

Though her reference was vague.

Xu Qingzhu, who had also drunk quite a bit, didn't react immediately: "Who?"

Shen Hui paused for a moment: "Zhao Xuning."

"She's already collapsed on the table." Xu Qingzhu didn't hide it: "We were just about to take her back."

"You've been drinking too." Shen Hui asked: "How are you going to take her?"

"We'll call a designated driver service."¹ Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi suddenly shouted from the side: "Shen Hui, if you can't let go of her, just come pick her up! I want to go back with Zhuzi... mmph..."

She was cut off mid-sentence when her mouth was covered. Liang Shi struggled twice but to no avail.

Her light brown pupils made her look innocent and pitiful.

But Xu Qingzhu glared at her, meaning she had said the wrong thing.

And Liang Shi was being covered so firmly that she could barely breathe. She subconsciously licked her lips, but ended up licking Xu Qingzhu's palm instead.

It was wet.

Xu Qingzhu's eyes immediately widened, but she didn't remove her hand.

Liang Shi, however, was like a mischievous child—when she drank too much, she always wanted to provoke people.

Seeing that Xu Qingzhu's expression was unfriendly, she continued.

While Xu Qingzhu was briefly distracted, Shen Hui said: "I'm near where you're eating. I'll go pick her up."

Xu Qingzhu thought she had changed her mind because of what Liang Shi said and was rushing over, so she immediately said: "No need... don't listen to Liang Shi's nonsense. We can take Zhao Xuning back."

"It's fine." Shen Hui said: "I'm here."

As soon as her words fell, the private room door was pushed open.

Xu Qingzhu immediately withdrew her hand. Her palm was very wet, as if she had broken out in a cold sweat.

She tightly clenched her palm, a trace of nervousness flashing through her heart.

As soon as Shen Hui entered the private room, she frowned: "What's that smell?"

"The smell of alcohol, probably." Xu Qingzhu said.

"Not just that." Shen Hui had always had a keen nose, but now there were too many scents mixed together, making it somewhat difficult for her to distinguish.

"There's a tea scent, and the smell of alcohol." Shen Hui said while helping Zhao Xuning up: "And also a bit of that rich strawberry scent."

She helped Zhao Xuning up and walked toward the door. The moment Zhao Xuning saw her, she suddenly curved her lips, and a particularly satisfied smile bloomed across her face.

Zhao Xuning's voice was hazy: "Wifey~"

She buried her head in Shen Hui's shoulder, and Shen Hui smacked her on the head—with quite a bit of force.

Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi simultaneously shrank back.

Shen Hui scolded: "Shut up!"

Xu Qingzhu felt a bit embarrassed, "Actually, we could have taken her back. Sorry to trouble you..."

"It's fine." Shen Hui was still cold and aloof, lowering her head to glance at the completely wasted Zhao Xuning, "Don't drink with her in the future. Her behavior when drunk is terrible—after she gets drunk... anyway, it's hard to describe in words."

"I'm leaving first." Shen Hui said: "I need to dump her back before she starts acting up. You two should go home too."

Just as she was about to go out the door, Liang Shi suddenly asked: "If you don't care about her, why did you still come?"

The air momentarily froze.

After a long while, Shen Hui said coldly: "I'm afraid she'll die outside."

Shen Hui said: "I need to keep her alive, so she can suffer forever."

Footnotes:

¹ "代駕" (dài jià) - A designated driver service very popular in China where you can hire a driver to drive your own car home when you've been drinking. The driver typically arrives on a foldable electric scooter or bicycle, drives you and your car home, then uses their scooter/bike to leave.

Chapter 133-5

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The entanglement between Shen Hui and Zhao Xuning was something Liang Shi truly couldn't understand.

She gave up trying.

When heading back with Xu Qingzhu, they called a designated driver service.

On the way, she rambled on apologizing to Xu Qingzhu, saying she shouldn't have said those things to Zhao Xuning.

She chattered the entire way, not even noticing that Xu Qingzhu was feeling somewhat unwell.

Returning to the home they hadn't been to in a while, although the place was small, it was very warm.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu went back hand in hand. They had just entered the door and hadn't had time to turn on the lights when Xu Qingzhu nearly fell to the ground. Fortunately, Liang Shi was quick to react and caught her.

Liang Shi was startled, half sobering up from the shock. She held her and asked: "What's wrong?"

"I..." Xu Qingzhu's gaze was hazy, her cool voice tinged with a bewitching quality.

The lights weren't on at home; there was only a faint light source.

But it was enough for Liang Shi to see Xu Qingzhu's face clearly.

Xu Qingzhu felt like her throat was on fire. She could smell the distinct scent of white tea, as well as the pheromones emanating from her own body.

Her heat period... had been delayed by more than half a month.

This time it seemed to come on fiercely, threatening to devour her rationality right from the start.

A heat period triggered by Alpha pheromones was more intense than ever before. Xu Qingzhu felt her legs go so weak she could barely stand.

Liang Shi reached out and turned on the light—only the entryway light.

The lighting was dim, but she could see Xu Qingzhu with her seductive, hazy eyes.

Xu Qingzhu's face was flushed red, her body seemingly enduring tremendous agony as she leaned her back against the door.

The scent of strawberry Baileys spreading through the air gave one a tipsy feeling.

Almost instantly, Liang Shi understood, "Your heat period has arrived?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded.

Liang Shi asked anxiously: "Where's the suppressant? Where did you put it?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, then suddenly curved her lips into a smile, "Jiejie~"¹

Liang Shi's throat moved slightly as she swallowed.

When she called her "jiejie," Liang Shi immediately recalled the previous memories.

It was that little princess of a younger sister.

Liang Shi responded in a low voice: "Hm?"

Xu Qingzhu's arms wrapped around her neck, "Are you still..."

She paused, then her voice became even more bewitching, almost whispering directly into Liang Shi's ear, "...un-a-ble?"

Liang Shi held her, even dragging her, afraid she would slide down along the door.

"I've remembered everything." Liang Shi leaned close to her, breathing warm air by her ear, "Little princess... meimei."²

Xu Qingzhu was momentarily speechless, dazed for two seconds.

"Where's your suppressant?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu stared at her, then sighed after a moment, "Jiejie~ how much more obvious do you need me to be?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"You won't regret it?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu lowered her eyelashes, her voice aggrieved: "Jiejie~ I feel awful."

Liang Shi reached out to lift her chin. When their eyes met, she leaned down and kissed her.

The air was filled with the mixed fragrance of white tea and strawberry Baileys.

Footnotes:

¹ "姐姐" (jiějie) - Means "older sister" in Chinese. It's a term of endearment that can be used for actual sisters or for older female figures one is close to. In romantic contexts, it can carry an intimate, sometimes flirtatious connotation.

² "妹妹" (mèimei) - Means "younger sister" in Chinese. Similar to "jiejie," it can be used as a term of endearment for younger women one is close to, and carries intimate connotations in romantic contexts.

